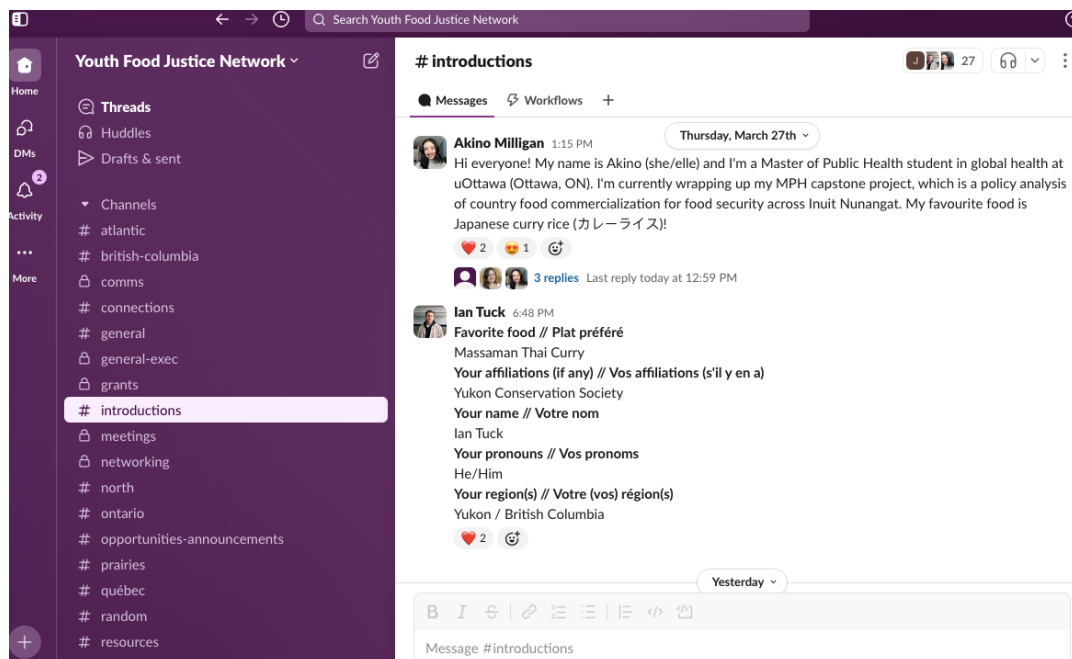


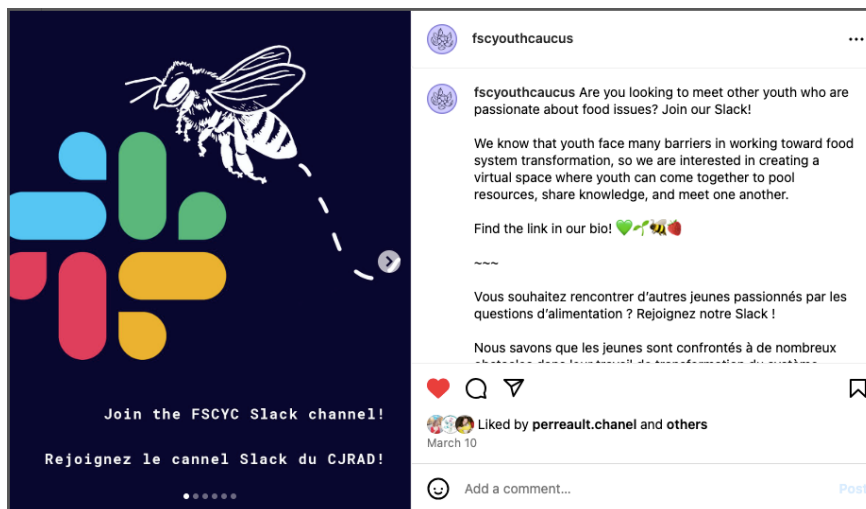
Dreaming of Food Futures: A FSC youth caucus project.

This project aims to connect youth together to work towards food justice and food security, and it has two main aspects: (1) We are creating a zine showcasing the work of youth across Canada envisioning just and sustainable food systems; and (2) We have created and are maintaining a Slack channel that is open to all youth and organizations interested in working together towards (the channel is called “Youth Food Justice Network”). The Slack channel has been shared on our social media, and can be joined by filling out this google form: <https://forms.gle/pLEBKiwSjEzFtMt17>

Below is a screenshot of the Slack channel in action; we have already onboarded 27 youth on the channel since launching it on March 10th, and we expect many more to join as we continue spreading the word.



Screenshot of the “Introductions” section of the Slack channel, in which new members have a chance to introduce themselves.

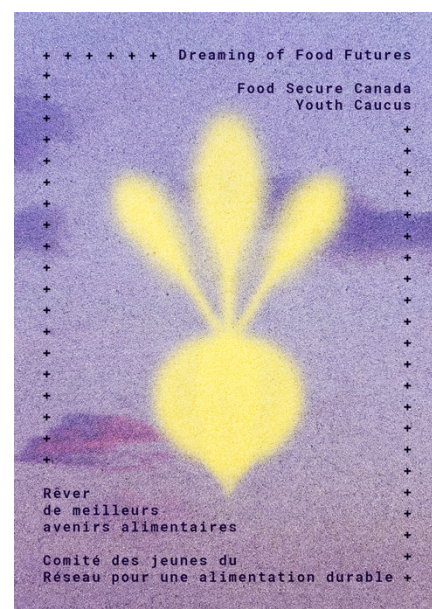


Our social media post launching the Slack channel publicly.

The Zine: Dreaming of Food Futures

Below are the submission proposals we collected via a Google form for the “Dreaming of Food Futures” zine, which will be launched April 2025. We received responses from diverse youth, who are now working on pieces that include poems, collages, drawings, interviews, and essays. We accepted the submissions outlined below, and have also invited these youth to join the Slack channel, where we will continue collaborating on the zine.

Right: Cover of the Zine “Dreaming of Food Futures”



Submission proposals:

(1) All my life is about food! I have a vegan food blog @ torontovegana showcasing affordable and accessible, culturally rich foods from a latinx perspective. I love cooking, growing food, talking about food. I'm doing my masters in environmental studies at York University studying food systems and food policy. I'm on the Toronto Youth Food Policy Council on both the communications and advocacy committees, running the social media, and helping with writing content. I believe everyone should have the right to food, despite food being commodified in Canada along with water. I'm anti-food waste. I would love to showcase a veganized version of a traditional Salvadoran dish in this zine.

I would like to showcase a vegan pupusa recipe, that has been passed along from my mom and from her grandmother. I'd like to highlight the most traditional forms of the dish, being corn and beans, ancestral ingredients from El Salvador, once known as Cuscatlan. When I think of food futures, I think of a future where we feel connected to our food, and this doesn't always mean what we think. For instance growing up, I felt disconnected from my cultural foods - having grown up here in Canada rather than my roots. Especially changing my diet for ethical and environmental reasons, even more disconnected from what people assume is latino food. Fast forward to finding out pupusas were originally vegetarian, maybe even vegan, from pre-Spanish colonization in my country. So, I would love to showcase the recipe. *Note: I would be flexible to pivot and write an essay as well, or along with the recipe. OR, a photography piece with text alongside. I'm flexible, would just love to be a part of this project.

(2) Food justice, security, and sovereignty were all terms I learned while sitting in a lecture hall in university, but like many people, I had practiced these ideas long before I could put a name to them. I study food policy and agriculture at university, but I feel most connected to these things when I get to practice them: while kneading dough in the morning for afternoon meal distribution, saving and drying tomato seeds for the seed library, collecting onion skins for bandana dyeing and most importantly -- when cooking and sharing meals with my community. My family settled on the territory of the Sylix, Ktunaxa, and Sinixt Nations and while my parents had limited fluency in the English language, food was the universal language that opened our neighbors doors to conversation, laughter, and love. Food security is so important to me not only because we "need it to survive", but because it has the capacity to nourish people beyond just filling a stomach. Food can be community. It always has been for me. I have 2 submission ideas:

1 - Themes: equity, food justice, food sovereignty, food security. I would like to take the idea of a "seat at the table" and make a multimedia collage piece of a table depicting local "place settings" to incorporate both the idea of place-making with culture and cultural foods. I was thinking of incorporating news sources about significant food sources/exports in BC (eg: blueberries, salmon) as the "napkin" and then my vision of food futures on the plates.

2 - "Downstream effect" typically has a negative connotation, especially in BC, where hydroinfrastructure has disrupted Indigenous communities access to the land and enacted devastating ecological harms. I would like to move beyond this idea and envision a future where we reconcile our place on the land as listeners and shared partners by illustrating a thriving river where flower-headed humanoid creatures and fish shared the streams together. I would hope to create natural dyes made from my table scraps (eg: onion skins) and pressed native flowers and flower petals to create the shapes of these figures.

(3) As someone living in a world where basic needs like food are increasingly out of reach for many, the issues of food security, food justice, and sustainability resonate deeply with me. I feel a passionate urgency around these topics, fueled by both personal experience

and reflection on my Austrian heritage. I think about my great-grandmother, now in her mid-nineties, who remembers a time when having something as simple as an orange was a rare luxury. Now, we find ourselves in a world where people struggle to afford enough to sustain themselves, and it's heartbreaking to see how far we've come—and how much we've lost—when it comes to ensuring that everyone has access to nutritious and sustainable food.

My submission will explore the intersection of tradition, food, and memory through the lens of my family's culinary history. I plan to conduct an interview with my grandmother, who grew up in Austria, to capture her experiences of cooking traditional recipes passed down from her mother, a skilled cook who made the most out of limited ingredients. Through this interview, I will trace my genealogical lineage and the role food has played in shaping my family's identity. The core of my submission will be a poem that intertwines these memories, focusing on the foods that marked my childhood, such as schnitzel, goulash, and spätzle. These dishes are not just meals; they represent a deeper connection to the past, resilience in the face of scarcity, and the art of nurturing family bonds with simple, yet meaningful ingredients. By exploring these traditional foods and their emotional significance, I aim to create a reflection on how food sustains us—not just physically, but culturally and emotionally—as we move into the future.

(4) I'd like to expand from food security videos I've already made. For the past 7 years, my career has been centered on climate justice via work experience and my Master of Climate change. Since 2019, I've worked with the charity WeCare Centre as a Community Relations Director to build trust with stakeholders from both the retailer and food processing sectors to secure low income locals with over 26,000 nutritious meals and divert 96,000 lbs of greenhouse gas emissions via food waste (worth over \$98,000). Additionally, I founded the Impossible Project, a hub inspired by climate grief and focused on navigating the mental toll of interconnected global challenges. This involved producing, editing, and platforming stories of wholistic well-being from marginalized voices via videos. My grassroots work has earned me the Co-operators Young Leaders Award due to its impact on food insecurity, one of many key socio-economic determinants of health.

(5) For the last six years, I've been concerned with the academic side of food security. I consider myself a food studies scholar, first and foremost. I'm passionate about food sovereignty and love to read about exciting initiatives that transform ideas of food justice into reality: non-profit grocery stores, mutual aid kitchens, guerrilla gardening turned agriculture, etc. Recently, I've been able to connect with a like-minded group of youth who share my excitement. We're quite literally called the Food Futures Youth Council - and it's been a great opportunity to turn my academic leanings into action.

My/our submission will explore our aspirations for the city of Ottawa (unceded Algonquin-Anishinaabe territory) where we live, eat, and grow. It will be a collaborative collage - handwritten messages will state our dreams for our local food system in the affirmative

("My community garden provides all that I need," for example), transforming the future into the present. Through this, it will allow us to explore our anxieties - the cost of living crisis, urban sprawl threatening farmland, monoculturalism - without giving in to them. It will reflect our diverse interests, reflecting the need for holistic and polycultural food futures.

(6) As a science communicator and climate storyteller, I am deeply passionate about food justice and sustainability. Through my workshops, podcast, and educational content, I explore the intersection of environmental issues, community well-being, and social equity. I have worked with many communities, including First Nations groups, on projects promoting energy sovereignty and climate resilience. In Montreal, I volunteer with a food charity called Santropol Roulant to improve urban agriculture, food accessibility, and community care models. These experiences have shaped my belief that food is not just sustenance—it's a powerful tool for community building, justice, and empowerment.

My submission will be a collage exploring themes of community care, resilience, and the interconnectedness of food systems. Using a mix of photographs, illustrations, and text, the collage will depict a vibrant tapestry of food futures rooted in justice and sustainability. Elements will include images of community gardens, seed libraries, farmers' markets, and traditional food practices. The piece will highlight how marginalized communities have historically led sustainable food movements and how their wisdom can guide us toward a more equitable future. The collage will invite viewers to imagine a world where food systems nourish both the planet and its people, emphasizing joy, connection, and collective empowerment.

(7) Hi! I'm Zhilu. For generations, my father's family were subsistence farmers. But in the 1970s, farming was no longer financially sustainable for them. Young people left for the cities, and elders sold the land to factories that polluted it. I grew up watching fragments of that land become dumping grounds for plastic waste. Over time, our family's connection to the land faded, wanting nothing to do with farming—a profession increasingly disrespected as "poor and uneducated" in rural China. I grieved the connection with land that I never got to have. Now, I work on projects in lab-grown meat advocacy, grant writing for precision agriculture, and outreach for a hydroponics company. I also volunteer at urban gardens and prepare food that we have harvested. My goal is to reconnect people with the food they consume and help agricultural professionals access technology that makes farming both financially and environmentally sustainable. I believe we are meant to have an intimate relationship with our land and food.

Food has once been an integral part of human lifestyle and livelihoods. Civilisations were classed by their primary mode of production – hunter-gatherer or agricultural. Yet, it now suffocates behind plastic. No scent, no touch, just a barcode and a nutritional table with counted calories. A necessity turned into a transaction. When did we sever our connection with what we put into our bodies? This poem explores the paradoxes of food consumption in the 21st century, and explores a future where food becomes a placeholder for memories, stories and histories, as well as just scents, colours and textures. It sees

futures where food is cultivated intentionally, prepared carefully and shared with loved ones – where enough time in our lives is spent on something so essential to being alive.

We are proud of the progress we've achieved so far, and we are excited to continue working on this project! We are consistently maintaining the Slack channel and recruiting more members, and we aim to launch the final version of the zine at the end of April 2025.

Food Secure Canada Youth Caucus